IOs may also face obstacles in reaching constituents because of low awareness of their existence or work. Surveys indicate that many citizens, particularly in countries like the United States, have little knowledge of IOs or their roles in global governance (Brutger and Clark 2022). Without established communication channels, IOs may struggle to reach or resonate with the public. Additionally, citizens might view IO outreach efforts as insincere or manipulative (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023), particularly if messaging is perceived as overly simplistic or disconnected from local realities. Such perceptions could backfire, reinforcing populist narratives that paint IOs as out of touch.

Efforts to sway public opinion can carry unintended consequences. Branding aid or assistance with an IO's name, for instance, might undermine a government's legitimacy by overshadowing its role in providing public goods. In fragile or weak regimes, this could exacerbate instability or even provoke backlash from leaders. Similarly, adopting populist rhetoric to appeal to citizens can alienate IOs' core constituencies, such as educated elites, who may view such messaging as disingenuous or pandering. If perceived as shaming or undermining a country's leadership, these actions could trigger a rally-'round-the-flag effect, bolstering public support for populists and intensifying opposition to IOs.

IOs thus must demonstrate their value in ways that resonate with the public while avoiding actions that could exacerbate tensions or erode trust. Effective communication, visible contributions to public welfare, and culturally sensitive outreach can help IOs walk this tightrope. However, they must remain mindful of the potential risks and limitations of this approach, tailoring their strategies to the unique political and social contexts they operate in.

2.3.4 Sidelining Populists' Constituents

A final approach available to IOs is to sideline the constituents of populist leaders, either by empowering nonpopulist domestic actors or by keeping the public unaware of the IOs' interactions with populist leaders. While this strategy can be effective under certain conditions, it also raises significant normative and practical concerns.